

Chuckwalla Care guide



A Comprehensive Guide

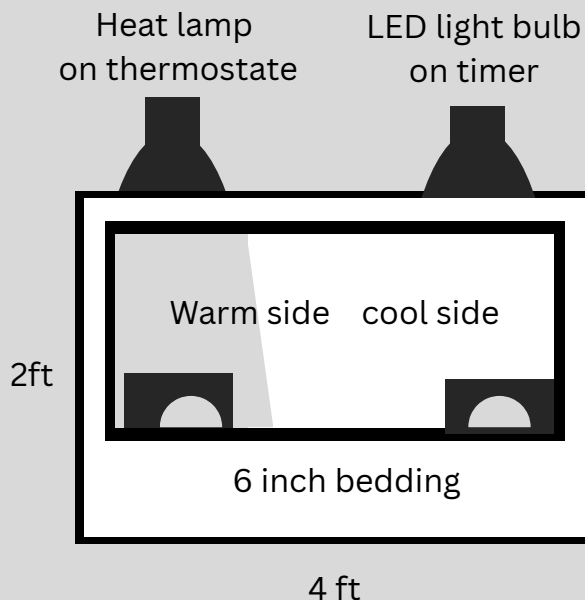
Enclosure

For an adult chuckwalla, I recommend at least a 4x2x2 enclosure, but bigger is always better. Chuckwallas are active, basking lizards that like to climb over rocks and explore their environment.

I recommend having:

A large basking area, Several secure rock crevices and hiding spots, Large, stable rocks and slabs, Branches or other climbing structures, Areas of both sun and shade, Deep enough substrate for natural digging behavior, A shallow water dish, Plenty of open floor space for movement

Make sure all rocks and climbing structures are extremely stable so they cannot collapse onto the lizard.



Heating and Temperature

Chuckwallas are desert baskers, so they need a hot basking area as well as a cooler area that they can move to when they need to lower their body temperature.

I recommend using an overhead heat source connected to a thermostat. The heat source should be positioned over the basking area rather than heating the entire enclosure.

Temperatures:

Basking surface: 110–125°F

Warm area: around 85–95°F

Cool side: around 75–85°F

The basking temperature refers to the surface the chuckwalla is sitting on, not the air temperature. Always use a thermostat with your heat source, and use an IR temperature gun to check the actual basking surface.

Lighting

Use a UVB light on a timer during the day. Place the UVB over the basking area so the chuckwalla gets UVB while basking.

Around 10–12 hours of light per day is a good starting point.

A separate LED light is optional if the UVB light provides enough visible light.

Turn the lights off at night.

Handling

Chuckwallas can become calm and comfortable with regular, gentle handling. Allow the chuckwalla to approach your hand rather than grabbing it whenever possible.

Support the entire body while handling and avoid grabbing or restraining the animal unnecessarily.

If the chuckwalla becomes stressed or tries to escape, return it to its enclosure and allow it to calm down.

Quick Setup

Enclosure: 4x2x2 minimum for many adults, bigger recommended

Heat: Overhead heat source

Thermostat: Yes

Basking surface: 110–125°F

Warm: 85–95°F

Cool: 75–85°F

Night: 65–75°F

Humidity: Dry/low to moderate

Lighting: UVB on timer

LED: Optional

Water: Fresh water available

Substrate: Dry, naturalistic, and burrowable

Food: Leafy greens, plants, flowers, cactus, and vegetables

Cohabitation: Not necessary

Temperature regulation: Provide a hot basking area and a cooler area so the chuckwalla can regulate its own temperature

For more information contact us at: ScaleWiseEducation@gmail.com

Feeding

Chuckwallas are primarily herbivorous and eat a variety of leafy greens, plants, flowers, and vegetables.

Good food choices include:

- Collard greens
- Dandelion greens
- Mustard greens
- Endive or escarole
- Prickly pear cactus pads
- Hibiscus leaves and flowers

- Squash and other appropriate vegetables
- Prickly pear: Remove all spines and tiny glochids before feeding.

Offer a variety of foods rather than feeding the same thing every day.

Feeding schedule:

- Adults: Once per day
- Juveniles: Once per day, with smaller portions

Provide fresh food in the morning and remove uneaten food later in the day.

Calcium and other supplements should be used according to the animal's diet and veterinarian's recommendations.

Never feed wild plants unless they have been positively identified as safe and are free of pesticides and herbicides.

Humidity

Chuckwallas are adapted to dry desert environments and generally do well with low to moderate humidity.

A normal household humidity level is generally acceptable as long as the enclosure has good ventilation and does not remain excessively humid. Fresh water should still be available.

Substrate

Chuckwallas naturally live in rocky desert environments, so use a dry, naturalistic desert substrate.

Good options include:

- Sand/soil mixes
- Naturalistic arid substrate
- Commercial desert reptile substrates
- Other dry, burrowable substrates

Give them enough substrate to allow for digging and natural behavior. The substrate should allow natural digging behavior while remaining dry and well-drained.

For medical treatment or quarantine, a simpler substrate such as paper may be preferable so waste and changes in condition can be easily monitored.